

Ai and environmental concerns

Posted by u/Coffee_Wizards • 0 points • 15 comments

This isnt meant as an attack on anyone, I'm honestly just trying to understand the argument better.

I see a lot of posts about AI being bad for the environment because of energy use, data centers, etc. And yeah, thats a real concern because energy consumption matters.

What I keep wondering though is how people are comparing that to... basically everything else we already use every day.

Phones, constant internet access, streaming, cloud storage, online gaming, fast fashion, shipping stuff overnight, replacing electronics every few years because all of that has a pretty big envirommental footprint too. None of it is exactly clean.

So I guess my question really is,

Is AI viewed as significantly worse than existing tech, or is it getting more pushback because it's newer and more visible right now?

Not trying to defend AI or say it's harmless. Just curious how people are weighing its impact compared to the rest of modern tech we already rely on

Comments

u/FitIndependence6187 • 1 points • 2025-12-28 14:26 UTC

From an environmental standpoint, AI is a win long term, but a huge blow to short term due to the reasons you pointed out. Long term though AI will likely at least assist in technological breakthroughs in Energy, atmospheric cleaning, etc. that will actually make us much better off than not having it.

It all depends on how long it takes to get to superintelligence where problems like fusion can be solved and implemented quickly.

As of right now it's going to make everything worse from a warming and energy conservation standpoint for sure.

u/coanbu • 1 points • 2025-12-28 21:01 UTC

>From an environmental standpoint, AI is a win long term

Correction it "might be" a win in the long run. There is no certainty to that at all.

More importantly the thing that is is consuming all those resources in the short term does not

really have much to do with those potential long term benefits. To achieve those there is no need to invest in all the generative "ai" that all the big tech companies are piling money in to.

u/thatsnotverygood1 • 0 points • 2025-12-29 04:19 UTC

You are correct, "might" is likely more accurate. However, at current levels of R&D productivity, I have absolutely no faith we'll develop the technology we need to reach de-carbonization goals without A.I. or some other massive productivity booster.

I'm also not really confident my country (and many others for that matter) can grow themselves out of their sovereign debt burdens fast enough to prevent defaults in the next twenty years, which would collapse the global economy and basically all concern for the environment.

I just think that most developed countries are in a bit of a tricky bind. They need to continue growing quickly while also decarbonizing and that's a pretty tricky thing to do. If AI actually becomes a profoundly useful technology maybe some of these problems might be a bit easier to solve.

u/Feather_Sigil • 2 points • 2025-12-28 01:47 UTC

AI is worse than other tech because it uses more resources and does nothing in exchange.

u/Mipibip • 0 points • 2025-12-28 01:00 UTC

It doesn't matter if it was actually that bad we'd force the end of driving 1 billion cars 2 times per day to the same six square miles and work remotely we don't need to go to the office all can be done remote

u/HellaTroi • 0 points • 2025-12-27 23:39 UTC

Data centers use as much energy as some small cities. But that's not the biggest problem.

It's the jobs issue.

I call my doctor's office to make an appointment. I no longer get Cindy on the phone. I get an AI phone response system. And that's just the beginning.

People will start losing jobs at a pace faster than we have already been experiencing.

They haven't told us what the plan is when that starts happening.

u/FitIndependence6187 • 1 points • 2025-12-29 14:10 UTC

The same plan as when the combustion engine was invented and put a million (a large chunk of the country at that time) people out of jobs. Or the computer putting 3.5 million Computers (humans doing math) out of a job.

Disrupting tech has always put large amounts of people out of work for a short period after which those people find new work. The invention of the computer for instance killed 3.5 million jobs, but created 100 million over the following years in programmers and techs.

u/OrenMythcreant • 2 points • 2025-12-27 23:31 UTC

We already use too much energy. Various "AI" expansions are radically increasing the energy we use, for very little apparent benefit.

If someone idles their car all day every day, it's just as wasteful despite the fact that you use your car to run errands.

u/notaredditer13 • 2 points • 2025-12-27 21:50 UTC

>or is it getting more pushback because it's newer and more visible right now?

That.

u/DiogenesKuon • 3 points • 2025-12-27 20:47 UTC

A ChatGPT query uses about as much energy as a lightbulb running for 30 seconds. That's more than it would cost to just look up the information on wikipedia, but at the same time you wouldn't hesitate for a second to turn a light on in a room to go read information from a book. So the cost at the user level is pretty trivial. The total cost of AI could become problematic if it continues to grow at a fast pace, but it's really more of a question of how much value we get out of AI versus its cost. If it shows significant efficiency gains then the net result is likely good, and if it doesn't then the bubble pops and you probably don't see the projected rapid growth.

u/archpawn • 4 points • 2025-12-27 20:13 UTC

[This article](<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/a-cheat-sheet-for-conversations-about>) has a few comparisons. ChatGPT is pretty minor compared to a lot of things people already don't care about.

A lot of people are biased against AI and try to argue that it's bad in every possible way, and will never repeat an argument that's in favor of it. Also, data centers are very efficient at using electricity, which leads to companies opening them and doing all their computations in one spot, which can strain the grid in that spot, which makes it more visible than something that uses electricity everywhere. That and the fact that it's new.

u/coanbu • 1 points • 2025-12-27 19:55 UTC

Three reasons:

First, it is a new thing. We need to be changing our energy system and electrifying a bunch of stuff, throwing a bunch of new demand on the system is pretty damaging.

Second, the energy use to benefit ratio. While there are certainly useful things LLMs can do. The vast majority of the energy is going in to pretty useless stuff, stuff that could be done in more efficient ways, or actively harmful things.

Third, if the tech companies are allowed to build it out at the rate they claim to want (and it does not all come crashing down first) it will start being a less and less trivial part of the pie.

u/Runiat • 4 points • 2025-12-27 19:49 UTC

>Phones, constant internet access, streaming, cloud storage, online gaming,

These are all extremely well optimised to use the bare minimum of both electricity and computational resources.

Because they need to be to make money.

AI has yet to start trying to make money, instead relying on investors pouring money into what may or may not be a bottomless hole.

>fast fashion, shipping stuff overnight, replacing electronics every few years

I'm not forced to do any of those whenever I want to look up something without appending some keyword that may or may not be the same next week.

u/The_Mythwalker • 1 points • 2026-02-26 15:34 UTC

I don't care about money. That's irrelevant. People use those things obsessively even when money isn't involved at all.

u/Samu_27 • 8 points • 2025-12-27 19:49 UTC

The thing is AI is worse because it's additive on top of all that other stuff. Like we're not replacing streaming with AI, we're just adding another massive energy sink. Plus the scale is insane, training one model can use as much power as thousands of homes

u/The_Mythwalker • 1 points • 2026-02-26 15:33 UTC

So... why do we use those *other* energy-depleting substances if depleting energy "is bad in general"?

u/EducationalMost4317 • 1 points • 2025-12-28 06:24 UTC

Yeah that's fair, the scale thing is probably what makes it feel different - like when you hear about training GPT-4 using as much energy as a small city it hits different than thinking about Netflix servers

u/Maleficent_Memory831 • 1 points • 2025-12-28 00:46 UTC

Plus, it provides no value.